INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #46 · GRIEF AND LOSS

# “I'll never get over losing them.”

✦ ✦ ✦

## Where it often comes from

Grief can feel endless, especially in the first year or after a sudden or traumatic loss. Well-meaning people may say “time heals” or “you should be over this,” and when it does not feel true, we conclude that something is wrong with us or that the pain is permanent.

## What Scripture teaches

Jesus said, “Blessed are those who mourn, for they will be comforted.” The psalmist says, “Weeping may stay the night, but joy comes in the morning,” and “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted.” Revelation promises, “He will wipe away every tear from their eyes.” Paul calls God “the God of all comfort, who comforts us in all our troubles.” Grief does not have a deadline, and many people never stop missing the one they lost. But the intensity softens, and joy and love can live alongside loss.

> *“For His anger is fleeting, but His favor lasts a lifetime. Weeping may stay the night, but joy comes in the morning”* (Psalm 30:5).

## Also see

> “Blessed are those who mourn, for they will be comforted” (Matthew 5:4).

> “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit” (Psalm 34:18).

> “‘He will wipe away every tear from their eyes,’ and there will be no more death or mourning or crying or pain, for the former things have passed away” (Revelation 21:4).

> “Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, the Father of compassion and the God of all comfort, who comforts us in all our troubles, so that we can comfort those in any trouble with the comfort we ourselves have received from God” (2 Corinthians 1:3–4).

## Common self-statements

- The pain will never lessen.
- I will always feel like this.
- I cannot go on without them.
- Life will never be good again.
- Something is wrong with me for still hurting.
- I will never be happy again.

## Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Predicting that the pain will never ease.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I must either be over it or be in agony.
- Should statements: Insisting that I should be over it by now.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling hopeless and concluding that things are hopeless.

## Challenging questions

- How has my grief changed since the first days, even slightly?

- What do I need right now: rest, company, tears, or help with practical tasks?
- What are healthy ways I can honor my loved one?
- What does it mean to “get over” someone I loved?
- How might God’s comfort come through people around me?
- Who can I talk to about how heavy this is?

## Truth summary

> I may always miss the one I lost, but the pain will not stay at this intensity forever. I can mourn, be comforted, and carry my love for them with me. God is near to the brokenhearted, and joy can return alongside the loss.

## Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Grief
- Sorrow
- Death/Dying
- Hardship
- Suffering

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Grief
- Suffering

## Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

## Songs that speak truth to this belief

**Just Be Held** — Casting Crowns
God’s care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

**The God Who Stays** — Matthew West
God’s faithful presence challenges the expectation of rejection and abandonment.

**He Knows** — Jeremy Camp
Jesus understands suffering and invites people to bring their burdens to Him.

**Softly and Tenderly** — Kristyn Getty with Vince Gill, Ellie Holcomb and Sierra Hull
This older hymn pictures Christ’s gracious invitation to return rather than hide in shame.

*Each morning ask: “If I truly believed God’s truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?”*

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

# My Plan for Replacing "I'll never get over losing them"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

## 1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

*Rate it now so you can see your progress later.*

"I'll never get over losing them." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

## 2 My best question

*The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.*

- ☐ How has my grief changed?
- ☐ What do I need right now?
- ☐ How can I honor them?
- ☐ Who can I talk with?
- ☐ Where have I felt comfort?
- ☐ What does God promise?

My own question: _____

## 3 My replacement truth

*The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.*

- ☐ Blessed are those who mourn.
- ☐ Weeping may stay the night, but joy comes in the morning.
- ☐ God is near to the brokenhearted.
- ☐ He will wipe away every tear.
- ☐ Grief has no deadline.
- ☐ Love and joy can coexist with loss.

In my own words: _____

## 4 My Scripture

*The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.*

- ☐ Psalm 30:5
  *"For His anger is fleeting, but His favor lasts a lifetime. Weeping may stay the night, but joy comes in the morning."*
- ☐ Matthew 5:4
  *"Blessed are those who mourn, for they will be comforted."*
- ☐ Revelation 21:4
  *"'He will wipe away every tear from their eyes,' and there will be no more death or mourning or crying or pain, for the former things have passed away."*

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

# Practicing the Truth

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## 5 My practice plan

*Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.*

### EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

### PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Comfort received: Each day, write one comfort you received and one memory you treasure.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  *For example, Psalm 30:5 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Weeping may stay the night, but joy comes in the morning.""*
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Grief" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

## 6 My action step this week

*Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.*

*Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.*

- [ ] Give grief room. Set aside time each day to remember and cry if you need to.
- [ ] Honor them. Do one thing in their memory, such as a visit, a gift, or a story.
- [ ] Find support. Join a grief group or talk with a pastor or counselor.
- [ ] Care for the basics. Sleep, eat, and move gently each day. If you have thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 right away.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

## 7 End-of-week check-in

*Bring this page to your next session.*

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I'll never get over losing them": _____ %  My truth: _____ %

## Daily practice tracker

| Day | Read my card | Said my verse | Used my reminder | Comfort received |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Mon | | | | |
| Tue | | | | |
| Wed | | | | |
| Thu | | | | |
| Fri | | | | |
| Sat | | | | |
| Sun | | | | |

## My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

| Day | Song I listened to | What it told me that challenges the lie |
|---|---|---|
| Mon | | |
| Tue | | |
| Wed | | |
| Thu | | |
| Fri | | |
| Sat | | |
| Sun | | |

## My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I'll never get over losing them.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

*Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.*

## Prayer

*Lord, I miss them so much. Comfort me as only You can. Be near to my broken heart, and carry me through the days when I cannot carry myself. Amen.*

*Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.*

# “If I had done something different, they would still be alive.”

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## Where it often comes from

After a death, the mind searches for what could have been done: a symptom missed, a call not made, a different route, a different decision. This is a normal part of grief, because the alternative, that we could not control it, is frightening. But it can turn into heavy self-blame.

## What Scripture teaches

The psalmist says, “My times are in Your hands.” Scripture teaches that God alone numbers our days. “Precious in the sight of the LORD is the death of His saints.” David, after his child died, said, “Can I bring him back again? I will go to him, but he will not return to me.” The psalmist says, “Even if He causes grief, He will show compassion according to His abundant loving devotion.” We act on what we know at the time. Hindsight gives clarity that was not available then, and love does not make us all-knowing or all-powerful.

> *“My times are in Your hands; deliver me from my enemies and from those who pursue me”* (Psalm 31:15).

## Also see

> “Precious in the sight of the LORD is the death of His saints” (Psalm 116:15).

> “Even if He causes grief, He will show compassion according to His abundant loving devotion” (Lamentations 3:32).

> “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit” (Psalm 34:18).

> “For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor principalities, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord” (Romans 8:38–39).

## Common self-statements

- I should have noticed.
- If only I had called sooner.
- It is my fault.
- I let them die.
- I could have prevented it.
- I will never forgive myself.

## Common logical errors

- Hindsight bias: Judging past choices by what I know now.
- Personalization: Taking responsibility for something beyond my control.
- Magical thinking: Believing that the right action would have guaranteed a different outcome.
- Should statements: Insisting that I should have known.

## Challenging questions

- What did I know at the time, and what did I only learn afterward?
- Could I realistically have prevented this?

- What would I say to a friend who felt this way?
- What did I do out of love?
- What does it mean that God holds our times?
- Is there something real I need to confess, and if so, what does God say about forgiveness?

## Truth summary

> I acted with the knowledge and strength I had at the time. Hindsight shows me things I could not see then. My times, and theirs, are in God's hands. I can grieve without condemning myself, and I can receive God's compassion.

## Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Grief
- Guilt/Shame
- Death/Dying
- God, All Knowing
- Forgiveness

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Grief
- Self-Esteem, Low

## Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

## Songs that speak truth to this belief

**Just Be Held** — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

**He Knows** — Jeremy Camp
Jesus understands suffering and invites people to bring their burdens to Him.

**Forgiveness** — Matthew West
Ask God for help releasing resentment while working through real hurt.

**Softly and Tenderly** — Kristyn Getty with Vince Gill, Ellie Holcomb and Sierra Hull
This older hymn pictures Christ's gracious invitation to return rather than hide in shame.

*Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"*

# My Plan for Replacing "If I had done something different, they would still be alive"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

## 1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

*Rate it now so you can see your progress later.*

"If I had done something different, they would still be alive." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

## 2 My best question

*The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.*

- ☐ What did I know then?
- ☐ Could I have prevented it?
- ☐ What did I do out of love?
- ☐ What would I tell a friend?
- ☐ What do I need to confess?
- ☐ Who can I talk to?

My own question: _____

## 3 My replacement truth

*The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.*

- ☐ My times are in God's hands.
- ☐ I acted on what I knew.
- ☐ Hindsight was not available then.
- ☐ God shows compassion.
- ☐ Love does not give control over life and death.
- ☐ I can be gentle with myself.

In my own words: _____

## 4 My Scripture

*The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.*

- ☐ Psalm 31:15
  *"My times are in Your hands; deliver me from my enemies and from those who pursue me."*
- ☐ Lamentations 3:32
  *"Even if He causes grief, He will show compassion according to His abundant loving devotion."*
- ☐ Psalm 34:18
  *"The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit."*

A verse I found myself: _____

# Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

## 5 My practice plan

*Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.*

### EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

### PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] What I did with love: Each day, write one thing you did out of love for them.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  *For example, Psalm 31:15 becomes: "Sarah can write: "My times are in Your hands, and so are theirs.""*
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Guilt/Shame" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

## 6 My action step this week

*Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.*

*Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.*

- [ ] Write what you knew then. List the information and options you actually had.
- [ ] Write a letter. Tell your loved one what you wish you could say.
- [ ] Talk to someone. Share the guilt with a pastor, counselor, or friend.
- [ ] Practice self-compassion. Say, "I did the best I could with what I knew."

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

## 7 End-of-week check-in

*Bring this page to your next session.*

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If I had done something different, they would still be alive": _____ %  My truth: _____ %

## Daily practice tracker

| Day | Read my card | Said my verse | Used my reminder | Love remembered |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Mon | | | | |
| Tue | | | | |
| Wed | | | | |
| Thu | | | | |
| Fri | | | | |
| Sat | | | | |
| Sun | | | | |

## My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

| Day | Song I listened to | What it told me that challenges the lie |
|---|---|---|
| Mon | | |
| Tue | | |
| Wed | | |
| Thu | | |
| Fri | | |
| Sat | | |
| Sun | | |

## My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If I had done something different, they would still be alive.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

*Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.*

## Prayer

*Lord, I keep asking what I could have done. You know my heart and You hold our days. Release me from self-blame, and help me trust that my times and theirs are in Your hands. Amen.*

*Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.*

INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #48 · GRIEF AND LOSS

# “Moving on means forgetting them.”

✦ ✦ ✦

## Where it often comes from

Many grieving people fear that feeling better is a betrayal. If we laugh, enjoy a meal, or begin to plan ahead, it can feel like leaving the person behind. Some hold on to pain because it feels like the last connection.

## What Scripture teaches

Solomon writes, “A time to weep and a time to laugh, a time to mourn and a time to dance.” Paul says, “We do not want you to be uninformed about those who sleep in death, so that you will not grieve like the rest, who are without hope.” The psalmist says that God keeps our tears in His bottle. Jesus wept, and so can we. David said of his child, “I will go to him, but he will not return to me,” and then he rose and went on living. Moving forward is not forgetting. We carry the people we love with us, and their memory can become a source of gratitude as well as pain.

> *“A time to weep and a time to laugh, a time to mourn and a time to dance”* (Ecclesiastes 3:4).

## Also see

> “Brothers, we do not want you to be uninformed about those who sleep in death, so that you will not grieve like the rest, who are without hope” (1 Thessalonians 4:13).

> “You have taken account of my wanderings. Put my tears in Your bottle— are they not in Your book?” (Psalm 56:8).

> “Jesus wept” (John 11:35).

> “But now that he is dead, why should I fast? Can I bring him back again? I will go to him, but he will not return to me” (2 Samuel 12:23).

## Common self-statements

- If I smile, I am betraying them.
- If I stop hurting, it means I did not love them.
- I must keep suffering to honor them.
- I do not deserve to be happy.
- Moving on is disloyal.
- I will forget their voice and face.

## Common logical errors

- Emotional reasoning: Feeling guilty about joy and concluding that it is wrong.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I must either grieve forever or forget.
- Should statements: Insisting that I should keep suffering.
- Catastrophizing: Imagining that healing means losing them.

## Challenging questions

- What would honoring them look like besides suffering?
- What would they want for me?

- What do I fear I will lose if I feel better?
- What can I do to keep their memory alive?
- How did people in Scripture mourn and go on?
- What small step toward living again could I take?

## Truth summary

> Moving forward does not mean forgetting. I can carry my loved one's memory with me and still laugh, plan, and live. Joy is not a betrayal, and honoring them can include living well.

## Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Grief
- Sorrow
- Death/Dying
- Joy
- Heaven

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Grief
- Depression

## Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

## Songs that speak truth to this belief

**Living Hope** — Phil Wickham
Christ's resurrection and forgiveness provide hope beyond sin and death.

**Just Be Held** — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

**Forever** — Kari Jobe
Christ's resurrection grounds hope in His victory over sin and death.

**Great Is Thy Faithfulness** — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

*Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"*

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

# My Plan for Replacing "Moving on means forgetting them"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

## 1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

*Rate it now so you can see your progress later.*

"Moving on means forgetting them." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

## 2 My best question

*The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.*

- ☐ What would honor them?
- ☐ What would they want for me?
- ☐ What do I fear losing?
- ☐ How can I keep their memory?
- ☐ What small joy can I allow?
- ☐ Who can I share stories with?

My own question: _____

## 3 My replacement truth

*The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.*

- ☐ There is a time to mourn and a time to dance.
- ☐ Joy is not disloyalty.
- ☐ I can remember and live.
- ☐ God keeps my tears.
- ☐ I grieve with hope.
- ☐ Their love lives on in me.

In my own words: _____

## 4 My Scripture

*The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.*

- ☐ Ecclesiastes 3:4
  *"A time to weep and a time to laugh, a time to mourn and a time to dance."*
- ☐ 1 Thessalonians 4:13
  *"Brothers, we do not want you to be uninformed about those who sleep in death, so that you will not grieve like the rest, who are without hope."*
- ☐ Psalm 56:8
  *"You have taken account of my wanderings. Put my tears in Your bottle— are they not in Your book?"*

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

# Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

## 5 My practice plan

*Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.*

### EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

### PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Remembering and living: Each week, note one way you remembered them and one way you lived fully.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  *For example, Ecclesiastes 3:4 becomes: "Sarah can write: "There is a time to mourn and a time to dance, and I can remember them while I live.""*
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Grief" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

## 6 My action step this week

*Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.*

*Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.*

- [ ] Create a memory ritual. Make a photo book, light a candle, or visit a place.
- [ ] Ask what they would want. Write what you think they would say about your life now.
- [ ] Allow a good moment. Let yourself enjoy something small without guilt.
- [ ] Share their stories. Tell others about them.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

## 7 End-of-week check-in

*Bring this page to your next session.*

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Moving on means forgetting them": _____ %  My truth: _____ %

## Daily practice tracker

| Day | Read my card | Said my verse | Used my reminder | Remembering and living |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Mon | | | | |
| Tue | | | | |
| Wed | | | | |
| Thu | | | | |
| Fri | | | | |
| Sat | | | | |
| Sun | | | | |

## My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

| Day | Song I listened to | What it told me that challenges the lie |
|---|---|---|
| Mon | | |
| Tue | | |
| Wed | | |
| Thu | | |
| Fri | | |
| Sat | | |
| Sun | | |

## My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Moving on means forgetting them.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

*Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.*

## Prayer

*Father, I fear letting go. Help me carry the love I have for them, honor their memory, and allow joy to return without guilt. Thank You for the gift of their life. Amen.*

*Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.*

INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #49 · GRIEF AND LOSS

# “God took them from me to punish me.”

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## Where it often comes from

After a death, guilt over old sins or an unresolved conflict can lead us to wonder if God is repaying us. People of faith can add to this by saying things like “God needed another angel” or “everything happens for a reason,” which can make God sound like the cause of the loss and imply that we deserved it.

## What Scripture teaches

Paul writes, “There is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus.” The psalmist says, “He has not dealt with us according to our sins or repaid us according to our iniquities.” When the disciples asked who sinned to cause a man’s suffering, Jesus said that it was not this man or his parents. Jeremiah’s lament says, “Even if He causes grief, He will show compassion.” And “God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us.” Death entered the world through sin and brokenness in general, not as a personal tally against you. God grieves with you.

> *“Even if He causes grief, He will show compassion according to His abundant loving devotion”* (Lamentations 3:32).

## Also see

> “Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus” (Romans 8:1).

> “He has not dealt with us according to our sins or repaid us according to our iniquities” (Psalm 103:10).

> “Jesus answered, ‘Neither this man nor his parents sinned, but this happened so that the works of God would be displayed in him.’” (John 9:3).

> “But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us” (Romans 5:8).

## Common self-statements

- I am being punished for my sin.
- God took them because of what I did.
- I deserved to lose them.
- God is angry with me.
- If I had been better, they would be here.
- This is the price of my past.

## Common logical errors

- Personalization: Believing the death was about me.
- Magical thinking: Linking my sin to a death.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling guilty and concluding that God punished me.
- Mind reading: Assuming I know God’s motive.

## Challenging questions

- What do I believe I did, and have I confessed it?
- Does Scripture teach that God kills loved ones to punish us?

- What did Jesus say when asked whose sin caused suffering?
- What does God's love at the cross say about His attitude toward me?
- Who said that God needed my loved one, and is that biblical?
- What do I need to bring to God in honest prayer?

## Truth summary

> God did not take my loved one to punish me. In Christ there is no condemnation, and Jesus rejected the idea that suffering is always payment for sin. God grieves with me, and I can bring my pain and any guilt to Him.

## Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Grief
- Guilt/Shame
- Forgiveness
- Death/Dying
- God, All Loving

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Grief
- Suffering

## Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

## Songs that speak truth to this belief

**Forgiveness** — Matthew West
Ask God for help releasing resentment while working through real hurt.

**Clean** — Natalie Grant
God's cleansing grace challenges the belief that shame or sin makes a person beyond restoration.

**Just Be Held** — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

**Amazing Grace** — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

*Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"*

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

# My Plan for Replacing "God took them from me to punish me"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

## 1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

*Rate it now so you can see your progress later.*

"God took them from me to punish me." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

## 2 My best question

*The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.*

- ☐ What do I think I am being punished for?
- ☐ Have I confessed?
- ☐ What did Jesus say about suffering?
- ☐ Who told me God needed them?
- ☐ What does the cross show?
- ☐ Who can I talk to?

My own question: _____

## 3 My replacement truth

*The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.*

- ☐ There is no condemnation in Christ.
- ☐ God does not repay me according to my sins.
- ☐ Not all suffering is punishment.
- ☐ God shows compassion.
- ☐ God proved His love at the cross.
- ☐ God grieves with me.

In my own words: _____

## 4 My Scripture

*The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.*

- ☐ Romans 8:1
  *"Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus."*
- ☐ Lamentations 3:32
  *"Even if He causes grief, He will show compassion according to His abundant loving devotion."*
- ☐ Psalm 103:10
  *"He has not dealt with us according to our sins or repaid us according to our iniquities."*

A verse I found myself: _____

# Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

## 5 My practice plan

*Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.*

### EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

### PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] No punishment: Each time guilt rises, write Romans 8:1 and one truth about God's compassion.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  *For example, Romans 8:1 becomes: "Sarah can write: "There is no condemnation for me in Christ, so this is not punishment.""*
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Guilt/Shame" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

## 6 My action step this week

*Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.*

*Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.*

- [ ] Name the guilt. Write what you think you are being punished for.
- [ ] Confess and receive. Bring any real sin to God and receive forgiveness.
- [ ] Read John 9:1–3. See how Jesus answered the question.
- [ ] Talk with a pastor. Share your fear and ask for biblical perspective.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

## 7 End-of-week check-in

*Bring this page to your next session.*

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "God took them from me to punish me": _____ %  My truth: _____ %

## Daily practice tracker

| Day | Read my card | Said my verse | Used my reminder | Condemnation answered |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Mon | | | | |
| Tue | | | | |
| Wed | | | | |
| Thu | | | | |
| Fri | | | | |
| Sat | | | | |
| Sun | | | | |

## My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

| Day | Song I listened to | What it told me that challenges the lie |
|---|---|---|
| Mon | | |
| Tue | | |
| Wed | | |
| Thu | | |
| Fri | | |
| Sat | | |
| Sun | | |

## My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~God took them from me to punish me.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

*Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.*

## Prayer

*Lord, I have wondered if You took them because of me. Thank You that there is no condemnation in Christ. Forgive what needs forgiving, and comfort me with Your compassion. Amen.*

*Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.*

# “Grieving shows a lack of faith.”

✦ ✦ ✦

## Where it often comes from

Some Christians are told to “be strong,” “rejoice, they are in a better place,” or “don’t cry.” Those words may come from love, but they can leave mourners feeling that tears are a spiritual failure. We then grieve privately or pretend to be fine.

## What Scripture teaches

“Jesus wept.” He wept at Lazarus’s tomb, knowing He was about to raise him. Isaiah describes the Messiah as “a man of sorrows, acquainted with grief.” Jesus said, “Blessed are those who mourn, for they will be comforted.” Solomon wrote, “A time to weep and a time to laugh.” Paul says we do not “grieve like the rest, who are without hope,” which does not mean that we do not grieve. The psalmist says that God keeps our tears. Tears and trust are not opposites. Deep grief often reflects deep love.

> *“Jesus wept”* (John 11:35).

## Also see

> “Blessed are those who mourn, for they will be comforted” (Matthew 5:4).

> “Brothers, we do not want you to be uninformed about those who sleep in death, so that you will not grieve like the rest, who are without hope” (1 Thessalonians 4:13).

> “You have taken account of my wanderings. Put my tears in Your bottle— are they not in Your book?” (Psalm 56:8).

> “He was despised and rejected by men, a man of sorrows, acquainted with grief. Like one from whom men hide their faces, He was despised, and we esteemed Him not” (Isaiah 53:3).

## Common self-statements

- Strong believers do not cry this much.
- If I really trusted God, I would be at peace.
- My tears show I doubt.
- I should be rejoicing, not mourning.
- People will think my faith is weak.
- I am letting God down.

## Common logical errors

- Should statements: Insisting that I should not grieve.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing faith and sorrow cannot coexist.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling sad and concluding that my faith is lacking.
- Mind reading: Assuming others judge my tears.

## Challenging questions

- Did Jesus grieve? What does that tell me?
- Who told me that grief is a lack of faith?
- What does “grieve with hope” mean?

- Can I trust God and cry at the same time?
- What do my tears say about my love?
- Who can I grieve with honestly?

## Truth summary

> Grief does not show a lack of faith. Jesus wept, and He blesses those who mourn. I can grieve with hope, cry honestly, and trust God at the same time.

## Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Grief
- Sorrow
- Death/Dying
- Faith
- Suffering

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Grief
- Suffering

## Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

## Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

The God Who Stays — Matthew West
God's faithful presence challenges the expectation of rejection and abandonment.

Broken Things — Matthew West
God can work through imperfect people without waiting for them to become flawless.

Softly and Tenderly — Kristyn Getty with Vince Gill, Ellie Holcomb and Sierra Hull
This older hymn pictures Christ's gracious invitation to return rather than hide in shame.

*Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"*

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

# My Plan for Replacing "Grieving shows a lack of faith"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

## 1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

*Rate it now so you can see your progress later.*

"Grieving shows a lack of faith." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

## 2 My best question

*The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.*

- ☐ Did Jesus grieve?
- ☐ Who told me grief is weak faith?
- ☐ What does hope mean?
- ☐ Can I trust and cry?
- ☐ Who can grieve with me?
- ☐ What psalm fits me?

My own question: _____

## 3 My replacement truth

*The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.*

- ☐ Jesus wept.
- ☐ Blessed are those who mourn.
- ☐ I grieve with hope.
- ☐ God keeps my tears.
- ☐ Tears reflect love.
- ☐ Faith and sorrow can live together.

In my own words: _____

## 4 My Scripture

*The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.*

- ☐ John 11:35
  *"Jesus wept."*
- ☐ Matthew 5:4
  *"Blessed are those who mourn, for they will be comforted."*
- ☐ Psalm 56:8
  *"You have taken account of my wanderings. Put my tears in Your bottle— are they not in Your book?"*

A verse I found myself: _____

# Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

## 5 My practice plan

*Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.*

### EVERYONE DOES THESE

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  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

### PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Tears and trust: Each week, note one time you cried and one time you trusted God in the sorrow.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  *For example, John 11:35 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Jesus wept, so my tears do not mean a lack of faith.""*
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Grief" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

## 6 My action step this week

*Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.*

*Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.*

- ☐ Read John 11. Notice that Jesus wept before He acted.
- ☐ Allow tears. Let yourself cry without apology.
- ☐ Find an honest friend. Share your grief with someone who does not rush you.
- ☐ Pray the Psalms. Pray Psalm 56:8 and others that voice sorrow.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

## 7 End-of-week check-in

*Bring this page to your next session.*

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Grieving shows a lack of faith": _____ %  My truth: _____ %

## Daily practice tracker

| Day | Read my card | Said my verse | Used my reminder | Tears and trust |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Mon | | | | |
| Tue | | | | |
| Wed | | | | |
| Thu | | | | |
| Fri | | | | |
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After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

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## My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Grieving shows a lack of faith.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

*Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.*

## Prayer

*Jesus, You wept. Thank You that tears are not failure. Meet me in my sorrow, give me honest friends, and hold me in hope. Amen.*

*Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.*